THE GLOBAL EMINENCE OF INDIAN VODKA

SMOKE LAB



Varun Jain
CEO, NV Group

One of the country's most successful distillers and brewers, NV Group is winning accolades for Brand India in the US market with its unfaltering expansion of Smoke Lab Vodka, the company's award winning premium vodka in the competitive American market. Headquartered in Delhi, the company is today showcasing India's finest quality ingredients and skilled craftsmanship to the world stage. We caught up with the CEO Varun Jain to know the secrets of the successful evolution of the company and its products.

With the innate 'tilak' adorning his forehead, Varun Jain is a young entrepreneur who wears his heart on his sleeve. Sustainability is at the core of his vision and has modelled his operations completely indigenous with world-class quality catering to global standards and a niche spirit market in the premium category. In his exquisitely styled office in central Delhi, he took us through the Smoke Lab studio, which houses the story of NV Group's growth, as we got ourselves delineated on the legacy and future plans of one of India's fastest growing spirit company.

Q The growth story of NV Group, its recent premium category launches and applause from the US market has been remarkable news for all of us. An Indian brand making it big in the premium category is extraordinary. What's behind it all?

I must agree. We started off the year quite remarkably. Smoke Lab is now not just available but it is also liked and patronised in much more regions in the US. The sales have gone up and we are geared to give a tough competition to the global big brands in many territories.

We are now available in New York, New Jersey, Connecticut, Rhode Island, Massachusetts, Maryland, Washington DC, Tennessee, New England, Kentucky, Georgia, Florida, Illinois, Nevada, Arizona and California. We are slated to expand further and preparations are underway.

Q You are keeping your cards too close to your chest. You still haven't opened up on the secret of this success.

I am proud to be leading a team which passionate and inspired to work towards this impressive expansion. The launch and the rapid growth would not have been possible without them. We have introduced distinctly unique vodka and that's the secret of our success. Its available in Classic, Aniseed and Saffron.

Q Your Vodka does not just taste distinct but it also looks different and is also served immaculately. What makes it so exquisite?

That has been our priority always. To evolve in style and with an Indian pride is our mission. We had the bottles being supplied outside India and we took the call to procure it from the domestic market to make the complete operation home-grown. Research and development is an integral part of our operation. We try to incorporate feedbacks from all the stakeholder of the Brand from the back-end factory worker to the Mixologists. The recent modification in our bottles is the measuring scale at the back that indicates the volume of spirit remaining in the bottle.

We are evolving and bettering ourselves in our benchmarks everytime. It's an opportune time to say that Indian brands are excelling and winning in global competition.

Q You have a sustainable and responsible entrepreneurial focus as part of your top priority. Please explain more about it.

Ever since my father founded this company, we have based ourselves on the ethos of 'Live Responsibly'. I am proud to say that we have created a unique sustainable model for the liquor industry in India and worldover. We make sure that we recycle and re-use the water so nothing is wasted and also use the by-products of the grains for animal fodder, amongst many other big and small initiatives taken by us to keep us as sustainable as possible throughout the manufacturing and supply chain.

Q Undoubtedly NV Group's journey has been inspiring. More inspiring has been its style, innovation and its relationship with its customers. What has always been your focus?

NV Group was established in the year 1994 and Smoke Lab was carved out in the year 2020. Today, we are one of the largest grain spirits distillers in India with an impressive range of brands in our portfolio. We cater to the domestic and international market with our finest blends in several categories including vodka, gin, rum, whiskey and RTDs. Our focus lately has been on the ultra-premium category which was untapped both in India and the exports to the global markets. We ensure Indian heritage and roots in every product that bears our name and I think that is what makes us stand apart in both Indian and the global market.

Q What's your message to your peers and the young entrepreneurs?

I would say, not to jump into any kind of business blindly. It is imperative to do your research and have a plan ready before venturing into starting something of your own.

India today holds immense opportunity for new ideas and ventures to bloom. We are a very business friendly ecosystem and the policy makers are backing growth oriented initiatives. It's time to explore and grow in style.